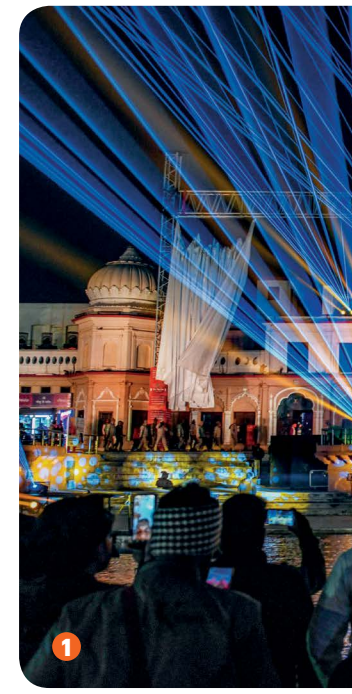
SIDELIGHTS

INSIDE Ram Rajya

Executive Editor-in-Chief *Kalli Purie* was among the 7,000 special invitees to the Pran Pratishtha ceremony at the Ram Mandir complex, Ayodhya. Her impressions...


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The celebrations started on the civilian jet aircraft itself that brought us to Ayodhya. The crew chanted Jai Shri Ram on the PA system and the passengers chimed in with mantras, bhajans and Hanuman Chalisa. The newly minted Maharishi Valmiki International Airport in Ayodhya was small yet efficient. When we landed, we were welcomed with Jai Shri Ram gamchas and yellow tikas of sandalwood paste by RSS workers. It was like landing at a destination wedding. Garlanded and marked, we were ushered into waiting cars.

As we drove down, I was amazed to see how the city stood transformed. The main arterial streets have been widened. All the shopfronts have been painted the colour of Jaipur sandstone and given uniform nameplates with a subtle mandir design on them rather than any loud hoardings. The street lamps are marked by Ram's dhanush and Hanuman's gada symbols. On Dharam Path, the main road leading up to the temple, the lamp posts have orb-like lights resembling the sun, a nod perhaps to Ram's Suryavanshi lineage.

For an event of this scale, you'd expect things to be chaotic. Instead, you were surprised by the meticulous planning. There may have been multiple security checks at the venue, but they were fast and efficient. Once done, golf carts took guests to the venue. Sadhus on golf carts made for an interesting sight. The walkways were wide and, every couple of metres, there were giant incense sticks. Volunteers at makeshift shoe depots helped everyone with their shoes. Once you finished taking off your shoes, you were given a spritz of rose water sanitiser. Khadaus were allowed!

Davos, Divas and Devotees

The guests were an interesting mix. There were corporates freshly returned from Davos, among them steel magnate Laxmi Mittal and Tata Sons chairman N. Chandrasekaran. Business icons Mukesh Ambani and Kumar Mangalam Birla came with their families. Gurus and sadhus like Sri Sri, Bageshwar Baba, Rambhadracharya formed another contingent. There were Bollywood stars too—from celeb couples like Alia Bhatt and Ranbir Kapoor, Katrina Kaif and Vicky Kaushal to Ayushmann Khurrana, Madhuri Dixit and Dr Nene, Anupam Kher, Kangana Ranaut and director Madhur Bhandarkar—as well as stars from southern cinema—Pawan Kalyan and Ram Charan.


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